

Word family: **route / routes / routed / routing / router**

Base word: route

Plural: routes

Past tense: routed

Past participle: routed

-ing form: routing

Related form: router

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Your sentence:

> “For example, he once spent fifteen minutes explaining why old tram **routes** can tell you more about a city than a history textbook.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **route** means a **fixed or usual path followed by public transport from one place to another**.

The speaker is referring to the paths along which trams travel through the city.

繁體中文： **交通工具按照既定安排來往不同地點時所行經的固定路線**

中文翻譯：

> “...why old tram **routes** can tell you more about a city than a history textbook.”

「.....為甚麼舊電車**路線**比歷史教科書更能告訴你一座城市的故事。」

Here:

tram route = 電車按固定安排行駛並停靠不同地點的路線

1. **route = path/way from one place to another (路線 / 路徑) — 路線；途徑**

This is the broad core meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A particular way or path used to travel from one place to another.

Practice 1 — Original

> “Old tram **routes** can tell you more about a city than a history textbook.”

「舊電車**路線**比歷史教科書更能告訴你一座城市的故事。」

Practice 2

> “We took a different **route** home to avoid the traffic.”

「我們為了避開交通擠塞，選了另一條**回家路線**。」

Practice 3

> “This is the fastest **route** to the airport.”

「這是前往機場最快的**路線**。」

route = 從一個地方前往另一個地方時所採用的特定道路、路徑或行進方向

Common:

- * bus route
- * train route
- * tram route
- * cycling route
- * walking route
- * shipping route

These are one underlying **physical travel path** sense.

2. **route** = regular transport/service path (交通服務路線) — 固定行車 / 運輸路線

This is especially relevant to your passage.

A **route** can refer not just to the physical roads taken, but to an **organized transport service with a regular path and stops**.

Practice 4

> “The company introduced a new bus **route** across the city.”

「公司新增了一條橫跨市區的巴士**路線**。」

Practice 5

> “Several tram **routes** were changed after the roadworks.”

「道路工程完成後，有幾條電車**路線**被更改。」

****transport route = 公共交通工具或運輸服務按既定安排所行經的一系列道路、地點或站點****

For database counting, I would ****merge this with Meaning 1****.

The difference is contextual rather than genuinely lexical:

> walking route

> tram route

> shipping route

all share the concept:

> ****a defined path between places****

That follows the Golden Manual's rule against splitting meanings merely because the transport type or context changes.

3. ****route = way/method to achieve something (方法 / 途徑) — 途徑；方法；渠道****

This is an important figurative meaning.

****Meaning:**** A way of achieving a particular result, entering a profession, reaching a goal, or progressing through a process.

Practice 6

> “University is not the only ****route**** to a successful career.”

「大學並不是通往成功事業的唯一****途徑****。」

Practice 7

> “There are several possible ****routes**** into the profession.”

「進入這個行業有幾種不同的****途徑 / 方法****。」

****route to something = 達到某個目標、結果或身分時可以採取的方法或途徑****

This is figurative:

> physical path → path toward an outcome

but the learner concept is different enough to keep separately.

4. **route** = prescribed process/channel (正式程序 / 渠道) — 程序 ; 正式渠道

A related but common institutional use describes the path through which a request, complaint, application, case, etc. must pass.

Practice 8

> “You should follow the official **route** for making a complaint.”

「你應該按照正式**程序 / 渠道**提出投訴。」

Practice 9

> “The application must go through the normal administrative **route**.”

「這份申請必須按照正常行政**程序**處理。」

route = 某件事情在機構或制度內需要依照的正式處理途徑或程序

I would **merge** this with Meaning 3 for core counting, because the broader idea remains:

> **a way/path by which something reaches a result**

5. **route** + data/call/traffic/message (資料 / 電話 / 訊息) — 傳送 ; 導向

As a verb, **route** means to direct something along a particular path toward a destination.

Practice 10

> “The system **routes** incoming calls to the correct department.”

「系統會把來電**轉駁 / 導向**正確的部門。」

Practice 11

> “Internet traffic is **routed** through several servers.”

「網絡流量會經由數個伺服器**傳送 / 路由**。」

route something = 按指定路徑把資料、訊號、電話、貨物等導向某個目的地

This is a genuinely important verb meaning, especially in technology and communication.

6. **route + vehicle/goods/person (交通 / 物流) — 安排經由某路線運送**

The verb can also apply to physical movement.

Practice 12

> “The buses were **routed** around the closed road.”

「巴士被安排**改道繞過**封閉道路。」

Practice 13

> “The goods were **routed** through Singapore.”

「貨物被安排**經由新加坡運送**。」

route something via/through somewhere = 安排某人、車輛或貨物沿指定路線前往目的地

For database counting, I would merge this with Meaning 5 under the broad verb concept:

> **direct something along a chosen path**

The thing being directed may be:

- * data
- * calls
- * vehicles
- * goods
- * messages

but the semantic idea remains the same.

7. **route = defeat completely (徹底擊敗) — 大敗；擊潰**

There is also a separate verb **rout**, meaning to defeat an opponent completely.

This is important because learners may confuse it with **route** due to spelling and pronunciation.

Practice 14

> “The home team ****routed**** their opponents 6–0.”

「主隊以六比零****大敗 / 擊潰****對手。」

Practice 15

> “The army was completely ****routed****.”

「那支軍隊被徹底****擊潰****。」

However, strictly speaking:

****rout ≠ route****

They are separate lexical words despite looking and sounding similar in some accents.

So under your SOP, I would ****not count this as another polysemy meaning of route****.

It belongs in an ****important contrast note****.

Related form: ****routing****

****Routing**** means the process or system of determining which path something should follow.

Practice 16

> “The software handles message ****routing**** automatically.”

「這套軟件會自動處理訊息****路由 / 傳送路徑安排****。」

Practice 17

> “Efficient delivery ****routing**** can reduce fuel costs.”

「有效率的送貨****路線規劃****可以降低燃料成本。」

****routing = 為資料、交通、貨物或訊息決定及安排傳送路徑的過程****

The exact Chinese depends naturally on context:

* network routing = 網絡路由

* delivery routing = 配送路線規劃

* call routing = 電話轉接路由

Related form: **router**

Router is a device or system that directs data between networks.

Practice 18

> “Restart the **router** if the internet connection stops working.”

「如果網絡連線停止運作，可以重新啟動**路由器**。」

Practice 19

> “The **router** sends data to the correct device.”

「**路由器**會把資料傳送到正確的裝置。」

router = 根據網絡路徑把資料封包導向正確目的地的設備

This is a highly useful technology-family extension.

It should not be mislabeled as another meaning of the noun **route** itself.

Important distinction: **route** vs **road**

road

= a physical built surface used by vehicles and people

> “This road is narrow.”

「這條道路很窄。」

route

= the overall path taken from one place to another

> “This is our route.”

「這是我們的路線。」

A **route** may include several different **roads**.

So:

****road = 實際道路****

****route = 前往目的地所採取的整體路線****

Important distinction: ****route vs path****

**route**

usually emphasizes an organized or chosen way between locations.

**path**

can mean a physical track or a more general course through an area.

> “a forest path”

= 森林小徑

> “a bus route”

= 巴士路線

They overlap, but ****route**** is especially natural when there is a clear origin and destination.

Important distinction: ****route vs direction****

**route**

= the entire path

**direction**

= the way something is facing or moving, or instructions for finding a place

> “Which direction is the station?”

= 車站在哪個方向？

> “Which route should we take?”

= 我們應該走哪條路線？

A route contains many possible changes in direction.

Important distinction: **route vs way**

Way is much broader.

It can mean:

- * physical path
- * method
- * manner
- * general means

Route is narrower and usually implies:

> **a defined course from one point toward another**

Compare:

> “What's the best **route** to the airport?”

= 最佳行車路線是甚麼？

> “What's the best **way** to learn English?”

= 學英語最好的方法是甚麼？

In figurative contexts, they can overlap:

> a route to success

> a way to succeed

Important distinction: **route vs routine**

These can look similar to learners but are unrelated in meaning.

route

= 路線 / 途徑

routine

= regularly repeated pattern of behaviour or activity

> “My bus route changed.”

= 我的巴士路線改了。

> “My morning routine changed.”

= 我的晨間習慣改了。

Important distinction: **route vs rout**

This spelling distinction is worth flagging.

route

= path / direct something along a path

rout

= defeat completely

> “The delivery was **routed** through another city.”

「貨物經另一個城市運送。」

> “The team **routed** its opponent.”

「球隊大敗對手。」

The second is from **rout**, not **route**.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **route**

* **routes**

* **routed**

* **routing**
* **router**

Useful compounds include:

* **bus route**
* **tram route**
* **trade route**
* **shipping route**
* **delivery route**
* **escape route**
* **route map**
* **routing table**
* **network router**

These compounds normally retain one of the established core concepts:

1. **a path/course**
2. **direct something along a path**

so they should not be counted separately simply because the domain changes.

The Golden Manual specifically requires useful compounds and modern specialist uses to be checked, while still merging those that share the same underlying semantic idea.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning	
-----	-----	
route — physical/travel path	從一個地方前往另一個地方時所採用的特定道路、路徑或行進路線	
transport route	公共交通或運輸服務按照固定安排所行經的一系列道路、地點或站點；屬於「路線」的同一核心義	
route to a goal/result	為了達到某個目標、結果、職業或身分而採取的方法、途徑或渠道	
official/administrative route	某件事情在制度或機構內按照規定所經過的正式處理途徑；屬於「方法 / 途徑」的延伸	
route something — direct along a path	按指定路徑把資料、電話、訊號、貨物、交通等導向某個目的地	
routing	為資料、訊息、貨物或交通決定及安排傳送路徑的過程	
router	在網絡中把資料導向正確目的地的設備	

For your original sentence

> "...old tram **routes** can tell you more about a city than a history textbook."

The exact meaning is:

route = 交通工具在不同地點之間按固定安排行經的路線

More specifically:

tram route = 電車從起點前往終點時固定行經的一系列道路和站點

So:

> **old tram routes**

= **舊有的電車路線**

For your database, I would count **3** genuinely distinct core polysemy/polyfunctionality meanings for **route**:

1. **physical or transport path from one place to another**
2. **figurative way/method/channel for reaching a goal or result**
3. **verb — direct data, traffic, goods, calls, etc. along a chosen path**

I would merge **tram route / shipping route / walking route** under #1, merge **official route / route into a career** under #2, and merge **route calls / route buses / route goods / route data** under #3.